

A Note on an Error of Representation in Parpola (1994)

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Abstract

In this brief note, the author points out how a specific Vedic ritual is misrepresented in [1], in a very significant work dealing with the interpretation of a seal from the Indus Valley Civilization (IVC). The note presents only a micro-sample of the potential errors that can creep into IVC script decipherment efforts when uninformed by the proper Vedic context.

On page 259 of [1], in a section entitled ‘Iconography of the Fig-Deity Seal,’ the author presents the following passage, reproduced here:

In eastern Bengal, a goddess of victory called Jaya-Durga is worshipped in the form of an earthen pitcher filled with water that is ‘placed either at the root of a tree or in some waste place unfrequented by human beings.’ Her non-Brahmin priests strip themselves naked and dance before the pitcher and thereby invoke her . . . Then twenty-nine diagrams of mystic significance are drawn with powdered rice . . . On each of these diagrams are placed oblations of boiled rice and roasted fish for the goddessling Jaya Durga. Last of all, beasts . . . are sacrificed and Homa ceremony is performed. (Mitra 1931: 970-1)

Here the reference at the end indicates that part of the passage might be sourced from elsewhere. Nevertheless, this passage is very significant for it is part of a section intended to suggest a way to the decipherment of the fig-deity seal and contains a few representational errors, by which we mean that Vedic culture is presented to suggest something different from what it actually signifies. For example,

1. The author suggests that the goddess herself is worshipped in the ‘form’ of an earthen pitcher. However, in the usual Vedic ritual, the pitcher is used as a part of the overall worship of the goddess. Here the presentation suggests that the pitcher *is* the usual ‘form’ of the goddess.
2. The ‘non-Brahmin’ nature of the priests is highlighted. This seems to suggest that the ritual is non-Vedic as well.

We may say that the IVC script might not be deciphered successfully without a correct sensibility about Vedic culture. The points presented here are a call to researchers to be better informed of the milieu of the IVC script - it is in roughly the same geography as the Vedic civilization, though temporally pre-dating it.

References

- [1] Asko Heikki Siegfried Parpola. *Deciphering the Indus script*. Cambridge University Press, 1994.